

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 25~07~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

Tens of thousands evacuated as wildfires sweep France, Spain

Reuters

Madrid, Paris, July 24

TENS OF thousands of people fled wildfires in southwest France by car and boat on Friday and Spain declared a national emergency as huge blazes merged outside Madrid and searing heat left tinder-dry conditions across the region.

French authorities ordered total evacuation of the Cap Ferret peninsula, a tourism hotspot on its Atlantic Coast. Two fires merged outside Madrid, and a third was on the verge of joining them, government officials said.

Both countries, which have suffered a succession of heat waves and fires in recent months and years that scientists say have been exacerbated by climate change, sought help from the EU



Smoke and flames rise as a wildfire advances near La Adrada, Ávila province, Spain, on Friday. AP

as the blazes strained emergency services.

Spain's national emergency — the first it had ever declared over a wildfire — opened up federal funding to tackle the crisis.

"This is the worst wildfire in our region's history," Madrid's regional leader Isabel Diaz

Ayuso said. "It's the perfect storm of very high temperatures and ceaseless winds that aren't letting up."

In southwest France, authorities sent boats to help the evacuation and a total of about 63,000 people were told to get out as two separate fires threatened homes.

UNESCO adds West Bank site, Lebanese castles to Heritage List

Associated Press

Seoul, July 24

UNITED NATIONS committee voted Friday to inscribe a major archaeological site in the West Bank and a set of castles in southern Lebanon as World Heritage sites, despite objections from Israel, which had urged the committee to reject the bids.

The decision at a UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization meeting in South Korea came days after Israel's Foreign Ministry urged committee to reject efforts to designate the small West Bank town of Sebastia and the Lebanese castles, calling nominations a "weaponization of cultural heritage."

At their meeting in Busan, members of the UNESCO com-

mittee decided to place Sebastia and five castles in Lebanon's Mount Amel area on both the World Heritage List and the List of World Heritage in Danger after reviewing the nominations on an emergency basis, citing ongoing conflicts in West Asia.

Sebastia, a hilltop town about 10 kilometers (6 miles) northwest of Nablus in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, is identified by scholars as ancient Samaria, capital of the biblical Kingdom of Israel.

The five castles in Mount Amel are recognized for their layered architectural heritage, combining Crusader, Ayyubid, Mamluk and local influences, reflecting the evolution of fortified architecture over nine centuries, as per UNESCO description.

SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2026



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BILL LIKELY IN PARLIAMENT MONDAY; PM THANKS PEOPLE FOR ‘POSITIVE SUGGESTIONS’

Jail up to 10 years, Rs 10-cr fine for exam leak: Nod for tough new law

Statutory backing for fast-track courts, 5 months for probe, trial

Damini Nath, Harikishan Sharma & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 24

A DAY after Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced fast-track courts and a tough new law to punish those involved in exam paper leaks, the Union Cabinet Friday approved a draft Bill with provisions for a jail term up to 10 years, penalty up to Rs 10 crore, statutory backing for fast-track courts and a five-month timeline for investigation and trial of cases, official sources said.

Hours later, in an Instagram post, Modi thanked everyone for the responses and positive suggestions received on his Thursday midnight video in which he announced the government’s decision.

“Thank you, friends. I got the opportunity to talk to you at midnight. The way you have responded to my video, positive suggestions given by you, thanks to everybody. Your love will continue to flow; our relations will continue with more bonding, Thankyou, thankyou friends,” he said in the new video message.

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Union Ministers J P Nadda and Jitendra Singh with CJP’s Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, Friday. ANI

SC bars court hearing clips on social media without approval



Direction by three-judge bench led by CJI Surya Kant

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 24

IN AN interim order Friday, the Supreme Court barred the recording and circulation of courtroom proceedings without prior permission of the court concerned. It concerns over alleged misuse on social media but clarified that the curb will not affect news reporting.

A three-judge bench, led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, said, “As an interim measure, we direct that there shall be no posting, reposting, extraction, modification, dissemination, monetisation, recording or review of the live-streamed proceedings of this court on social media or any other digital platform without the prior permission of the concerned registrar and the secretary general of this court and registrar general of high courts.”

Directing the secretary general of the Supreme Court and registrar general of high courts to display this order on their court websites, the bench said, “This order shall have no bearing on news reporting.”

The bench, also comprising Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana, was hearing a PIL by journalist Harshita Grover highlighting “increasing misuse of audiovisual recordings of judicial proceedings through selective clipping, editing, decontextualised

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POLITICS PAGE 5

CJI: COCKROACH REMARKS ONLY FOR FAKE LAW DEGREE HOLDERS

• ELECTORAL ROLL REVISION IN SOME OF STATE’S MOST INACCESSIBLE VILLAGES

Rivers rising, BLOs in Punjab’s border areas take boats to meet SIR deadline

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, July 24

FOR MOST Booth Level Officers (BLOs), revising electoral rolls means walking from one house to another with forms in hand. For some in Punjab’s remote border belt, it has meant rowing across rivers, waiting out flood-waters and, on occasion, relying on Army boats to return home.

As the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls gathers pace, BLOs posted in some of Punjab’s most inaccessible villages have been navigating swollen rivers and flood-prone terrain to ensure

that even the state’s last voters, living on the edge of the India-Pakistan border, are not left out.

In Gurdaspur district, Vikram Singh’s workday begins not on a road but on the Ravi. To reach Bharyal village, he boards a small country boat at Makaura Pattan, near the confluence of the Ravi and Ujh rivers. Villagers ferry him across to a settlement that remains cut off from the mainland for months every year.

“With rains lashing Jammu and Kashmir and the river getting into spate, it becomes difficult. I had to go daily. I wanted to finish my work before the monsoon. I have been able to

identify 60 percent of the voters. It was not an easy task,” Singh told *The Indian Express*, adding that SIR is still underway.

Bharyal, which has 369 voters, is inundated almost every year. Many of its residents temporarily move to 15 neighbouring villages during the flood season.

“I had to map each one of them. Like today, it is raining and I cannot go,” Singh said.

Bharyal and neighbouring Toor village, covered under Polling Station Nos. 1 and 2 of the Dinanagar (SC) Assembly constituency, are among Punjab’s most isolated habitations. Pakistan lies on one side, the Ravi



BLOs Pushpa Grover and Darshan Singh cross the Sutlej on a boat to reach Kaluwala village in Punjab’s Ferozepur district. EXPRESS

on the other, while the international border is barely 8 kilometres away.

Of Punjab’s 12,500 villages, 50 are considered remote because they are located along the

officials to send a “strong message”. These are “only the initial steps” in reforming the functioning of the agency, and “several more stringent and reform-oriented measures” are likely to follow, the sources said.

In a separate statement signalling wider reforms within the NTA, the Education Ministry said it has issued advertisements for the appointment of senior professionals at the level

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

SECTION 301 FORCED LABOUR PROBE

India attracts 10% US tariff, lower rate after policy shift

12.5 per cent for Vietnam, China: Trump administration redraws tariff architecture

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 24

THE US Friday imposed 10% tariffs on India, lower than the 12.5% rate proposed in March when the United States Trade Representative (USTR) identified 60 countries under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, citing import of goods produced with forced labour.

This comes weeks after the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) announced prohibition of import of goods produced using forced labour, along with parallel negotiations for a trade deal with the US.

In the new tariff regime enforced Friday, the European Union and Taiwan received the most favourable rates — the Section 301 tariff is applied on goods from these two economies only if the product’s existing most favoured nation (MFN) tariff is less than 10%. If

E. EXPLAINED

Bar on import of forced-labour goods

Ahead of the US tariffs, India barred the import of goods made using forced labour. On July 13, the Directorate General of Foreign Trade had inserted a new paragraph in the Foreign Trade Policy regarding ‘forced labour’, stating that import of goods produced or manufactured, ‘wholly or in part’, through the use of forced labour is ‘prohibited’.

the product from the EU or Taiwan already has an MFN tariff of 10% or higher, the Section 301 tariff is zero.

India has been placed in the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

HC: OpenAI’s use of copyrighted material to train ChatGPT ‘fair’

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 24

THE DELHI High Court has held that OpenAI’s training of its large language models (LLMs) on original retrieved copyrighted works constituted fair dealing, and did not amount to infringement of copyright.

The interim ruling Friday by Justice Amit Bansal extends a measure of legal cover to developers of artificial intelligence (AI) chatbots such as OpenAI to continue training on Indian-origin content without licensing agreements, and also interprets broadly what constitutes “fair use” of copyrighted works.

The suit, the first of its kind in Indian jurisdiction, was moved by news agency ANI Media Pvt Ltd in 2024 against OpenAI Inc and OpenAI OpCo LLC, seeking an injunction against the use of

its copyrighted content in the training of LLMs.

California-based OpenAI is the developer of the ChatGPT series of generative AI models. Open AI OpCo LLC is the commercial arm of the organisation.

“...in my prima facie view, Open AI’s acts of storage of the literary works of ANI for the training of its LLMs would fall under Section 52(1)(a) of the Copyright Act (fair dealing) and hence, would not amount to infringement,” Justice Bansal ruled.

He took into consideration that OpenAI’s use of the copyrighted works for training its LLMs is “completely an internal process” and does not involve providing the copyrighted material to any third party.

“I am also of the prima facie view that the outputs generated

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

New law

The Cabinet, sources said, approved a proposal to amend The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. Under Section 10 of the Act, the punishment for individuals resorting to unfair means is imprisonment of three to five years and a fine up to Rs 10 lakh. Section 11 provides for imprisonment of five to 10 years and a fine of at least Rs 1 crore for those involved in organised crime.

Without specifying if it would be applicable to individuals or organised crime, sources said the Bill would increase the imprisonment term up to 10 years and a fine up to Rs 10 crore.

Among the proposed amendments in the Bill is a time-bound investigation and trial of paper leak cases within five months. According to sources, the proposed amendments in the law provides a two-month time frame for investigation of paper leak cases and three months for completion of trials of such cases. Thus, the Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

paper leak cases will be fast-tracked and will be taken to conclusion within five months, the sources said.

The fast-track courts to be set up for such cases would be given statutory backing through the Bill, the sources said.

The existing law that came into effect on June 21, 2024 aimed to curb leaks, malpractices as well as organised malpractices in public examinations conducted by the Union Public Service Commission, the Staff Selection Commission, the Railway Recruitment Board, the Institute of Banking Personnel

Selection and the National Testing Agency which, among others, conducts the NEET exam.

Sources said the amendment Bill is likely to be brought in Parliament Monday, as announced by the Prime Minister Thursday.

Earlier Thursday, Law and Justice Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said the fast-track courts would be set up in the High Courts of Bombay, Calcutta, Delhi and Madhya Pradesh where cases pertaining to the NEET paper leak are ongoing.

The bench asked the various high courts to submit reports on the adoption of its livestreaming guidelines. It also asked the Centre to appraise which minis-

SC clips

circulation, and commercial exploitation on social media and digital platforms”.

The plea said, “Isolated courtroom exchanges, oral observations, and preliminary remarks are frequently extracted from lengthy hearings and circulated without the factual or legal context in which they were made. Such clips are often accompanied by misleading captions, sensational commentary, and clickbait headlines designed to maximise public engagement and commercial gain.”

It said unchecked circulation of such content had exposed judges, advocates and litigants to unwarranted criticism, trolling, vilification, and reputational harm. “More importantly, it risks undermining public confidence in the administration of justice by creating distorted and incomplete narratives regarding judicial proceedings,” it said.

The bench asked the various high courts to submit reports on the adoption of its livestreaming guidelines. It also asked the Centre to appraise which minis-

tries could implement the reliefs sought.

Appearing for Grover, Senior Advocate Vikas Singh expressed apprehension on clips of hearings being edited and circulated on social media.

“I personally don’t see any problem with livestream,” he said, referring to the recent instance of a hearing before a bench wherein the petitioner threw files and used abusive words, going viral on social media. “Adding words and showing clips is also happening,” he said.

Justice Bagchi said that once such live streams are uploaded on digital platforms, it becomes difficult to manage their circulation. “Regulating data is one of the biggest challenges in digital space... so we should ensure limited access and therefore restrict livestream itself. Parties must expressly make a prayer that they want to see. It can’t be a 24/7 entertainment channel by court... That belittles the justice system,” he said.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta pointed to the dangers of AI and said some tools can alter the words spoken by someone while preserving the lip movements.

10% tariff

second tier where the US has imposed a standard 10% tariff rate on 17 economies — others in the category are Argentina, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Canada, Ecuador, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras, Indonesia, Jordan, Malaysia, Mexico, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Trinidad and Tobago, and the United Kingdom.

“Based on the findings in the investigation of India, including India’s adoption of a forced labor import prohibition subsequent to the publication of the June 5, 2026 FRN, and considering the public comments and testimony, the advice of the Section 301 Committee, as well as the advice of advisory committees, and in accordance with the specific direction of the President, the Trade Representative has determined to impose 10% tariffs on products of India,” the USTR said.

The standard 10% tariffs on India are similar to those on ASEAN countries such as Malaysia and Indonesia but better than Vietnam which now falls under the least favourable countries with 12.5% tariffs alongside China, Russia, Brazil, Australia, the Philippines, Turkey and Saudi Arabia.

Under the new tariff design, Japan, South Korea and Switzerland are placed better than countries such as Vietnam and China, as they are subject to a 12.5% rate net of MFN.

Similar to the EU and Taiwan mechanism, their duty is determined by MFN plus Section 301. Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG9mljMzg1

BLOs

Sutlej on three sides and the India-Pakistan border fence on the fourth, it sits barely a kilometre from the international border. The village has little permanent infrastructure and is accessible largely by boat. Temporary Army pontoon bridges are erected only during emergencies. Repeated floods and its location on the border have forced many residents to move away, leaving behind a population of about 200.

For Darshan Singh and Pushpa Grover, teachers at Government School, Tendiwala, carrying out the SIR has meant making repeated boat journeys across the Sutlej.

“There are 150 voters. I have completed 82 percent of my work,” Darshan Singh said. “Some residents who have gone out of the village will re-

turn after planting paddy. Earlier, I used to go every day. The villagers are adept at rowing boats and we have been using them.”

Pushpa Grover said, “I have also been taking the boat to reach the village. The pontoon bridge is no longer there... I live in this area, so it is not a hardship for me. I have completed 90 percent of my work. The rest will be done soon.”

Despite their isolation, villages such as Kaluwala have consistently recorded high voter turnout.

Punjab Chief Electoral Officer Anindita Mitra said the exercise had highlighted the dedication of BLOs working under difficult conditions. “The BLOs have shown tremendous professionalism in carrying out the SIR in Punjab. They took whatever route was available. They are the praiseworthy partners in the SIR and have done commendable work,” she said.

five years at a senior level in investigation, vigilance or law-enforcement.

The GM (Assessment Research and Development and Psychometrics) will head the agency’s academic and measurement-science function and will be responsible for item banks or digital repositories of questions, normalisation methodology, equating and calibration procedures, and pilots on computer-adaptive testing and AI-assisted assessment.

As for the 16 young professionals, the Ministry said: “The engagement is open to candidates who have appeared in the Civil Services Examination and are on the Pratibha Setu portal, with 12 positions in academic research, two in legal research and two in finance and accounts.”

MEA pushes back on Wang’s remark attributed to Jaishankar

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 24

TWO DAYS after China claimed that External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar had told Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi that India’s positions on issues concerning Taiwan and Xizang (Tibet) have not changed, and that India respects China’s sovereignty, Delhi pushed back on Friday, clarifying that what Jaishankar actually said was “when it comes to sovereignty issues, it is actually India that should be and is raising them”.

Jaishankar and Wang met in Manila, The Philippines, on July 22 on the sidelines of the ASEAN and East Asia foreign ministers meeting, where the Indian minister had underlined that “peace and tranquility in the border areas” is the prerequisite for normal ties — Delhi’s position on the border standoff for the last six years.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry readout in state-run news agency *Xinhua* had stated, “Jaishankar said that India’s positions on issues concerning Taiwan and Xizang have not changed, and India respects China’s sovereignty.”

Responding to questions

about the readout, the MEA’s official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, “Yes. External Affairs Minister said that when it comes to sovereignty issues, it is actually India that should be and is raising them. India does not violate China’s sovereignty in any manner and has been consistent. But China is in illegal occupation of Indian territory in Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh since 1963, where India’s right is officially acknowledged even by China. Also, there are Chinese projects on territories in Jammu and Kashmir that belong to India, and we object to that.”

On July 22, Jaishankar had said, “Peace and tranquility in the border areas is obviously the prerequisite for normal ties. Since October 2024, both sides have engaged to ensure that important objective. This will continue to need our constant attention. Relevant mechanisms in this domain must be given full support and strong encouragement.” This was a reference to the India-China agreement on disengagement, after a four-year border standoff in eastern Ladakh, which was agreed in October 2024 and completed in November 2024.

OpenAI

by ChatGPT using the RAG (retrieval-augmented generation) technique does not amount to infringement under the Copyright Act since the outputs generated by OpenAI were not substantially similar to ANI (inputs),” he said.

Justice Bansal said ANI had “failed to satisfy” the court “that any memorisation or regurgitation” of ANI’s copyrighted works happened through the responses generated by ChatGPT”. The “balance of convenience” was in favour of OpenAI, the judge said — “irreparable injury would be caused not only to OpenAI but also to the public at large” if any interim injunction was granted in favour of ANI.

Two district courts in the US took a broadly similar line in two closely watched copyright cases that were decided within days of each other in June 2025. A group of writers had filed a class action complaint against Anthropic, the company behind the Claude family of LLMs; in the second case, a group of authors had sued Meta Platforms, whose research division Meta AI has developed the chatbot Llama.

The judges held that AI works did not substitute for the original works; rather, they generated something new from them. The ruling in the Meta case underlined that the plaintiffs had not shown that the training measurably harmed the market for their books. Both US verdicts have been relied upon by the Delhi High Court in its ruling.

Several media and publishing organisations and associations such as the Federation of Indian Publishers, Digital News Publishers Association, and the Indian Music Industry had joined as parties to ANI’s suit and raised similar objections to OpenAI’s training model.

On Friday’s ruling, IP lawyer Amit Kumar Panigrahi, partner at Kochhar & Co., said the verdict, apart from being a boost to developers, is likely to prompt copyright owners to revisit their contractual frameworks, including licensing models and AI-specific restrictions in content access and use agreements.

NTA

of General Manager in the agency to oversee key functions such as its network of centres, operations, information security and vigilance.

The Ministry also said it would engage 16 young professionals in various units of the NTA through the Pratibha Setu portal of the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC).

The portal is a Government initiative that allows “verified employers — including ministries, PSUs, autonomous bodies, and private organizations — to access details of non-recommended willing candidates who cleared all stages of UPSC exams but didn’t make it to the final

merit list”.

These appointments, the Education Ministry said, will mark “the first concrete step in the institutional rebuild of NTA” being implemented in line with the recommendations of the high-level committee of experts chaired by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan.

The *Indian Express* had first reported on July 7 that the Government is all set to overhaul the NTA, covering its organisation, infrastructure, technology and processes.

According to the Education Ministry, four contractual positions of General Manager — each for an initial term of three years — have been notified: Test Centre Network and Operations; Information Security; Vigilance, Investigation and Forensics; and

Assessment Research and Development and Psychometrics.

The General Manager (Test Centre Network and Operations) will lead the NTA’s nationwide test-centre footprint, spanning over 500 cities and select international centres. The GM will be responsible for empanelment standards, capacity planning, centre quality, accessibility for candidates with disabilities, hygiene and amenities, exam-day operations, and coordination with states.

The General Manager (Information Security), who will be designated as NTA’s Chief Information Security Officer, will head cyber-security and be responsible for all agency systems, applications, networks and data.

The position will also specifically be responsible for com-

Bill criminalising insult to Vande Mataram introduced in House

**Nikhil Ghanekar, Asad
Rehman & Anonna Dutt**

New Delhi, July 24

AMID CONTINUED demand for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, the first week of the Monsoon Session ended in a washout on Friday, with the exception of the introduction of The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, in the Rajya Sabha.

The Bill seeks to amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, to make insults to National Song Vande Mataram a criminal offence, punishable with imprisonment up to five years.

Proceedings in both Houses on Friday began with paying homage to members of the Armed Forces killed during the Kargil War, ahead of the Kargil Vijay Diwas on July 26 (Sunday).

Soon after, the Opposition MPs resumed their protest. Real Creator IAS Edition <https://>



Congress MPs Mallikarjun Kharge and Priyanka Gandhi, along with TMC MP Sagarika Ghose and others raise slogans seeking the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi, Friday. PTI

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t>
against the NEET paper leak,
resulting in both Houses get-
ting adjourned until 12 noon.

When the Lok Sabha met again, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said, "If we don't have a discussion and make excuses, then it is not a good message. I request

Gandhi ji that he should make the Congress MPs understand. Other party MPs have put their views that there should be a discussion. Why can't we have a good discussion?"

LoP Rahul Gandhi sought to speak after Rijiju's remarks, but BJP's Jagdambika Pal, who was presiding over the House, said

he would allow him time to speak after papers are laid on the table. The Opposition members started raising “istifa do” slogans, and Pal adjourned the proceedings till Monday.

Speaking to reporters in the Parliament complex, Gandhi said, "Rijiju ji gave a statement that they want our MPs to hold a discussion. The normal protocol is that if someone names a person, he or she is allowed to respond. When I wanted to reply, the mic was taken away from me. I was not given an opportunity," he said. Gandhi reiterated the Opposition's stance that they will not have a discussion or conversation on NEET until Pradhan is sacked.

In the Rajya Sabha, proceedings were adjourned till 2 pm. When the business resumed, Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai proposed to introduce 'The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026'.

The Bill seeks to make intentionally preventing the singing of the National Song or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing an offence with a maximum punishment of five years, or fine, or both. It also seeks to accord the same statutory protection to the National Song as the National Anthem.

As the Opposition benches protested the Bill's introduction, Deputy Chairman of Rajya Sabha Harivansh allowed CPI(M) MP John Brittas and CPI MP Sandosh Kumar P to speak on the Bill. "The Constituent Assembly, after nearly three years of exhaustive deliberation, consciously refrained from placing the National Song and the National Anthem on the same constitutional footing. Had the framers of both intended to enjoy identical legal consequences, they would have expressed and so provided," Brittas said.

With bipartisan support, how House passed 2024 anti-paper leak Act

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 24

Barely two-and-a-half months before the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the then Narendra Modi government brought the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Bill, 2024, in Parliament, which sought to prevent “unfair means” in order to “bring greater transparency, fairness and credibility to the public examinations system”.

These exams include common entrance tests and government recruitment exams conducted by “public examination authorities” such as the UPSC and NTA, among others. The Bill was passed by both Houses in February 2024 during the Budget Session.

Amid its current standoff with students and protesters led by the CJP, the Modi govern-

ment is planning to amend the 2024 Bill to make it more stringent.

Piloting the Bill in Lok Sabha on February 6, 2024, Union Minister Jitendra Singh underlined that while the Bill seeks to punish officials or organisations that indulge in various exam malpractices, including leaks of question papers and tampering of answer sheets, students or candidates will not come under its purview.

While the Act stipulates a prison term of three to five years and a fine up to Rs 10 lakh for any person resorting to unfair means in exams, it provides for a jail term up to 10 years and a fine over Rs 1 crore, in cases of “organised” paper leaks.

The Bill had bipartisan support in both Houses.

Introducing the Bill in LS,

Singh flagged media reports about 18-year-old Niharika Solanki, a JEE aspirant from Kota, who had died by suicide two days before exam on 31 January 2024. The minister quoted from the girl’s suicide note: “Mummy, papa, please forgive me. I cannot do it. I am the worst daughter.”

Singh had said the government was taking steps to serve the youth just months after it had passed a constitutional amendment legislation, 2023, to provide for one-third reservation for women in LS and Assemblies.

“In all provisions made for the youth in the last 10 years, it has been seen that there is transparency and that the youth get opportunities in keeping with their talent (*pratibha*), ability (*yogyata*) and hard work (*parishram*),” Singh had said.

He noted that most of the exams were now computer-based to ensure transparency.

Singh pointed out that there have been complaints in recent years that question papers have been leaked, citing instances of impersonation and papers being solved outside the exam centres. He gave such examples from the then TMC-ruled West Bengal in 2022, the then Congress-ruled Rajasthan during 2018-2022, and J&K between 2017 and 2022.

Supporting the Bill, Congress MP K Suresh had urged the government to use the latest technology to ensure that there were no exam irregularities. Then Congress leader in LS, Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, had said that the Bill “lacks preventive measures to reduce such acts”.

DMK MP D M Kathir Anand also said that the Bill “only talks about imprisonment, punish-

ment and fine”, adding that it has “not said anything about how these malpractices can be controlled”.

In his reply, the minister said that “punishment itself is a deterrent meant for prevention”.

While supporting the Bill, NCP (SP) leader Supriya Sule asked what difference it would make. “There is a system in place. If there is any scam, people do get caught. Then... what are you bringing in today in the Bill that didn’t exist in the past?”

TMC MP Kalyan Banerjee said the categories of offences mentioned in the Bill were already covered in IPC and BNS 2023. The deficiencies, he noted, were not in the absence of laws, but in their implementation.

Replying to the debate, Singh said: “This is a specific legislation because in the existing BNS, offences like these are not specifi-

Govt orders GitHub to block Bitchat app that works without Internet

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 24

AMID REPEATED mobile Internet shutdowns around Delhi’s Jantar Mantar, the site of the ongoing students’ protests, the government has directed GitHub to disable access to repositories hosting Bitchat, an offline messaging application developed by Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey.

“The government of India does not like technologies like Bitchat and wants it taken down,” said Jack Dorsey, platform’s co-founder. Dorsey also shared a copy of the blocking order by Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), under the MHA, issued to GitHub on July 23. According to the order copy shared by Dorsey, I4C said the app could be used to evade lawful surveillance and coordinate unlawful assemblies during restrictions on Internet services.

The order invoked Section 79(3)(b) of the IT Act, 2000, along with Rule 3(1)(d) of the IT

Rules, 2021, and asked GitHub to disable access to three repositories linked to Bitchat within three hours. The URLs include the app’s main source-code repository, its Android repository and a page used to distribute its Android installation file.

Bitchat is an open-source, decentralised messaging app that can allow users located near each other to communicate without mobile data, Wi-Fi, phone numbers or centralised servers. Its offline mode uses Bluetooth Low Energy to connect nearby phones, with each device capable of relaying messages to others and thereby extending the network’s reach.

The order, shared by Dorsey, said the app’s design “creates a substantial risk of misuse by anti-national elements, terrorist organisations, organised criminal groups, and cybercriminals seeking to evade lawful detection” despite “legally imposed restrictions”. Queries sent to Home Ministry remained unanswered until publication.

took it were “roaming free”. He alleged that the online exams had become a major source of corruption, suggesting that all exams be held offline.

Backing the Bill, BJP MP Prakash Javadekar praised the NTA formed under him, saying it was set up since PM Modi wanted “purity” in exam system. Significantly, it was under NTA that the 2024 and 2026 NEET-UG paper leaks took place.

Then AAP MP Sandeep Pathak, who defected to BJP in 2026, said there were 70 paper leaks in seven years prior to 2024. Pathak suggested that the guilty in such cases be given life imprisonment and their property confiscated. Singh quipped that as per his proposal, the property of all AAP leaders in jail should be confiscated. After the minister’s short reply, the Bill was passed.



Commercial vessel attacked in Black Sea, Indian killed

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 24

AN INDIAN seafarer was killed in an attack on a ship while it was reportedly transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea on July 18, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday. This came to light days after four Indians were among 10 killed in an attack on a commercial vessel off the coast of Ukraine on July 19.

“It has come to our attention that on July 18, the commercial vessel MV OMORFI was attacked while transiting the Black Sea, reportedly in Russian territorial waters. At the time of the incident, there were 10 crew members on board, including three Indian nationals,” the MEA said.

“As per available information, one Indian national tragically lost his life in the attack. We extend our deepest condolences to the bereaved family of the deceased. The other two Indian nationals on board are reported to be safe,” MEA said.

It said the Indian mission in Russia has reached out to the relevant authorities and is making efforts to extend all possible assistance to the affected family.

“India unequivocally condemns such attacks targeting commercial shipping and plac-

ing the lives of innocent civilian crew members at risk. It is a matter of serious concern that the freedom of navigation and international commerce is facing increasing threats,” the MEA said. “India calls upon all concerned parties to uphold international obligations to ensure the safety and security of maritime navigation and uninterrupted flow of global commerce.”

On Tuesday, New Delhi had summoned the Russian charge d’affaires following the killing of the four Indians in the strike on the MV Golden Leo vessel on July 19.

In response to Moscow indicating that the ship in Black Sea was targeted for carrying military supplies for Ukraine, India on Friday said that the vessel was carrying “grain” as cargo.

During a weekly briefing, the Ministry of External Affairs’ official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, while responding to Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov’s comments, said: “As per information made available to us from the Directorate General of Maritime Administration, India, MV Golden Leo, the Guinea-Bissau-flagged commercial vessel involved in the tragic incident in the Odesa port, had loaded grain as cargo prior to departure on 19 July 2026...”

Boulders roll down on taxi in Lahaul-Spiti, infant among 13 killed

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, July 24

ALL 13 occupants of a taxi, including a six-month-old child, were killed as massive boulders suddenly fell from a hill and crushed the moving vehicle in Himachal Pradesh’s Lahaul and Spiti on Friday, police said. The overloaded taxi, a Tata Sumo, also caught fire in the incident that took place near Kuddu Nala on the Udaipur-Killad road, they said.

While Deputy Commissioner, Lahaul and Spiti, Kiran Badana confirmed that 13 people have died in the accident, local MLA Anuradha Rana said 10 victims deceased belonged to Pangri in Chamba district, while three, including a woman and her infant, were from Lahaul and Spiti.

According to the preliminary information, the passengers had remained stranded overnight at Tindi as the Udaipur-Killad road was closed for traffic the previous day. They set off for Pangri in the morning after the road reopened.

Apart from the infant, the victims include seven men and four women. They were identified as Bir Singh, Buthi Singh,



Wreckage of the vehicle in Lahaul-Spiti on Friday. PTI

Bir Singh, Kamla Kumari, Anil Kumar, Rekha, Saurabh Singh, Anjana, Soman Angmo, Aaru (the infant), Sanjay Kumar and Hans Raj, DC Badhana said.

MLA Rana said, “The weather was clear, but there were reports of shooting stones in the area. All the bodies were recovered from the mangled vehicle and taken to the Civil Hospital at Udaipur for post-mortem examination.”

Rana said there was no telecom signal at the accident spot and she used a satellite phone to reach out to SP (Lahaul-Spiti) Shivani Mehla for carrying out rescue and relief operations.

Personnel from the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) reached the spot as did police teams from Lahaul and Tindi, and officials from Udaipur administration and other emergency agencies.

Expressing grief, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu directed that all possible assistance be provided to the next of kin of the deceased.

In a separate incident, a woman died and seven people were injured in a landslide in Mandi.

The Shimla Met office, meanwhile, issued an orange warning of heavy to very heavy rain state from July 27 to 29.

Ken-Betwa stir claims its first win, activist suspends fast

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 24

EIGHTEEN DAYS after beginning an indefinite hunger strike against alleged irregularities in the rehabilitation of families affected by the Ken-Betwa Link Project in Madhya Pradesh, Jai Kisan Sangathan leader Amit Bhatnagar on Friday suspended his fast, saying the agitation had achieved its “first success” after the state agreed to conduct fresh village-level surveys to identify families left out of compensation and rehabilitation.

Bhatnagar, who has been leading the Ken-Betwa Chita Andolan, said he was ending only the indefinite fast and not the movement itself.

“After achieving the first success of this 18-day indefinite fast, I am suspending my hunger strike today. But this struggle has not ended. From today, I am taking a pledge of ‘Nyay Satyagraha’. Until the last eligible person receives justice under the project, I will not rest. I will go from village to village, lead this movement, cooperate with every positive step taken by the administration and monitor every promise. If required, the next phase of the agitation will also begin,” he said.

The rehabilitation process concerns villages falling within the Daudhan Dam submergence zone. Bhatnagar had alleged that hundreds of eligible families were excluded from rehabilitation lists, that compensation assessments were flawed, and that Gram Sabha proceedings contained irregularities.

According to Bhatnagar, district authorities have agreed to form joint teams comprising officials and representatives of the Jai Kisan Sangathan to conduct fresh village-by-village surveys in Chhatarpur district and include every eligible family that had been left out.



India has ridden out crisis of Iran war, but a much bigger challenge is upon it

DONALD TRUMP’S foreign policy in his second term has been uncomfortable for India. But it has revealed a pressing reality: The country faces a 1991 challenge and more in economics and geopolitics.

In 1991, India faced its most serious economic crisis since Independence. Its finances put it in danger of sovereign default. On the back of the 1990-91 Gulf War, India’s import bill ballooned. Delhi was forced to get an IMF loan and send gold shipments to the UK, Japan, and Switzerland to tide over the foreign exchange crisis.

The year 1991 was also the end of the Cold War. To India’s shock, its security backstop against China and the US disappeared along with the Soviet Union. Falling massively behind the Western countries economically, plus the failures in Afghanistan, irreparably strained the Soviet political system.

India faced a third challenge with US pressures on nuclear proliferation, on human rights (in Kashmir, Punjab, and the Northeast), and on India’s closed economy.

A fourth challenge was China. Twelve years into its economic reforms, China was rising rapidly. It grew at 9 per cent per annum over the 12 years from 1979, and its GDP stood at \$380 billion. India grew on average at about 5 per cent after 1979. With a GDP of \$270 billion, it was already falling behind.

Finally, in 1991, Pakistan was triumphant. It had partnered the US and China to

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drive the Soviets out of Afghanistan and felt it was on the winning side in the Cold War (in comparison with India).

In 2026, 35 years later, we find ourselves at a strikingly similar conjunction.

The Indian economy once again faces huge challenges. Clearly, its financial position in 2026 is far more robust than in 1991. On the other hand, the rupee depreciated against the dollar and FII’s moved capital out of India. As in 1991, a Gulf war impacted India, this time leading to energy shortages and inflation. Worryingly, growth remains at 6 per cent, consistent with the 30-year average, but well below the 8 per cent benchmark.

The problem today, though, is not so much in the macro-economy. The problem is in four Cs — commerce (manufacturing), critical minerals/rare earths, computer chips, and computer software and infrastructure for AI. The challenges here are far greater than in 1991. In 1991, a series of structural reforms fixed the crisis and set India on a new growth path — relatively simple to do.

The challenge of the four Cs is much greater. Manufacturing is stagnant despite 30 years of encouragement. We have critical minerals/rare earths but have not sufficiently mapped and mined them; processing is another challenge altogether. Meanwhile, dependence on China ranges from 50 per cent to nearly 100 per cent across minerals



KANTI BAJPAI

In 1991, the US pressured India on nuclear proliferation, human rights, and its economy. In 2026, US pressures are on Indian exports, trade-related labour and other standards, and imports of Russian oil

and metals. On chips, NITI Aayog estimates that 90-95 per cent of India’s demand until 2035 will be met by imports. And in AI, India has strengths in adoption and talent, but not much of a presence in the AI value chain.

Geopolitically, too, India faces a situation arguably more difficult than in 1991. Today, the US is retreating from its alliances. And the special relationship with India is over: India is just another transactional opportunity, not a partner. In effect, India’s backstop against China has disappeared, with the added threat that Washington is eyeing a G-2 accommodation with Beijing.

In 1991, the US pressured India on nuclear proliferation, human rights, and its economy. In 2026, US pressures are on Indian exports, trade-related labour and other standards, and imports of Russian oil — hardly trivial areas.

By 1991, China was rising but its GDP was only slightly bigger than India’s. In 2026, it has a \$20 trillion economy. At 3 per cent growth rates, China’s economy will double by 2050. India’s GDP is \$4 trillion. At 6 per cent growth rates, India’s GDP will be \$16 trillion in 2050. The current \$16 trillion GDP gap will become \$24 trillion in 2050.

As for Pakistan, it is once again triumphalist. It feels it did well in the fight with India in 2025. It is integrated deeply with the Chinese military. It is on good terms with China, the US, and Russia, and in

2025, signed a defence agreement with Saudi Arabia. It was also one of the key mediators between the US and Iran in 2026.

What does all this mean for India’s grand strategy?

The economy needs a Manhattan Project on the four Cs, nothing less. Otherwise, India will be stuck at 6 per cent growth rates. And if India does not progress on the four Cs, averaging 6 per cent could become challenging.

Geopolitically, India’s approach to the US and China needs serious thought. Are we content with a “hide-and-bide” strategy with both superpowers where we stay out of their way and concentrate on reforms in our economic journey? Is motoring along in our own lane enough? Should we simply avoid any more bumps with the US and focus more on China? Is “doing a China on China” the answer — using Chinese imports, investment, and innovation to drive India’s growth, as the Chinese did with the US after 1972? Will China indulge us, like the Americans indulged China, without a more fundamental reset with Beijing? What would a more ambitious reset with China mean?

To conclude, India has ridden out the immediate economic crisis of the Iran war and shifting geopolitics of the past year, but a much bigger challenge is upon it.

The writer is visiting professor, International Relations, Ashoka University, and emeritus professor, Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy, National University of Singapore

Dwindling space for dialogue, not disagreement, is the problem



SAVITA JHA

A CONVERSATION with my daughter brought all my certainties into question. “Mom, why aren’t you at Jantar Man-tar?” I replied that I do not necessarily agree with the politics or methods of those leading the current protest. She sounded disappointed.

Then I realised that we were having two different conversations. I was thinking about the politics of the protest. She was thinking about the reason for it. For her, the real issue was not who stood at the front of the march, but the children whose lives have been shattered because the state failed to ensure an examination process that is secure, transparent, and accountable. On that, I cannot disagree with her. Children have an extraordinary ability to cut through ideology and ask the simplest, hardest questions: If the system failed them, shouldn’t we all care? Perhaps that is the conversation we should be having.

The Kathopanishad reminds us that civilisations do not progress by silencing uncomfortable questions; they progress by engaging with them. While talking of Indic culture, what has been our defining political instinct? India’s has never been conquest; it has been conversation. At a time when democracies across the world are becoming increasingly polarised, India faces a quieter but perhaps more profound crisis — the gradual death of dialogue. Protests are met with suspicion. Social media has become so politically consequential that governments contemplate restrictions. The judiciary increasingly performs the role that politics once did: Creating space for dialogue.

That should concern us all. Our foundational texts are conversations, not proclamations. The Bhagavad Gita unfolds as a dialogue. It begins with Arjuna’s doubts. Krishna responds by expanding the horizon of inquiry. The Upanishads are conversations between teacher and seeker. Buddhist councils institutionalised debate. Jain philosophy celebrated *anekantavada* — that truth may possess multiple dimensions. Gandhi’s *Hind Swaraj* is structured as a dialogue between editor and reader. Gandhi understood that persuasion produces more enduring political legitimacy than coercion ever can. Dialogue, therefore, lies at the heart of the Indic intellectual tradition.

Yet contemporary politics appears increasingly uncomfortable with this inheritance. Across the political spectrum, firmness is often projected as leadership, while dia-

logue is caricatured as indecision or weakness. The hardening of the state’s position becomes a political performance in itself. Consider the recurring crises surrounding public examinations. Every year, paper leaks, procedural irregularities, delayed recruitment, or flawed evaluation systems generate widespread anxiety. One may disagree with particular protests but dismissing protestors cannot erase institutional failures. India today speaks confidently about AI, digital governance, and becoming a global technology leader. Governments have access to some of the country’s finest scientific and technical minds. Yet examination systems affecting millions remain vulnerable to failures that students themselves are often able to identify. If technology, expertise and resources exist, where does the problem lie?

The answer may be less technological than political. Institutions improve only when they are willing to listen. A system that assumes criticism is hostility eventually stops learning from its own failures. Technology cannot compensate for administrative indifference. Algorithms cannot substitute for accountability. The larger danger lies in a political calculation that these failures carry only temporary electoral consequences. History offers a different lesson. No democracy can indefinitely govern through narrative management alone. Governance is ultimately measured not by the ability to shape public perception but by the willingness to correct institutional shortcomings. India’s greatest political thinkers understood this. Gandhi insisted that disagreement was not an obstacle to nation-building but one of its essential conditions. It reflected faith that truth could withstand scrutiny.

Perhaps that is the question confronting India today. Can a republic that invokes Gandhi, celebrates the Bhagavad Gita, and speaks of its civilisational continuity afford to abandon the principle that animates all three — the belief that conflict must culminate in conversation? If dialogue dies, institutions may continue to function, elections may continue to be held, and governments may continue to command majorities. But something far more fundamental begins to erode. The tragedy is not that India faces disagreement. The tragedy would be if the world’s oldest continuing civilisation forgot that its greatest strength has always been its ability to turn disagreement into dialogue.

The writer teaches history at Delhi University

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Trump’s Saudi nuclear gambit marks a shift

WASHINGTON’S DECISION to sign a civil nuclear cooperation agreement with Saudi Arabia marks an important shift in Middle East geopolitics — and highlights the growing role of advanced technologies in the regional power balance. The agreement will face close scrutiny in the US Congress, along with opposition from Israel’s supporters and the non-proliferation community. The deal will help Riyadh build a civilian nuclear energy programme and reduce its dependence on hydrocarbons. Washington wants American companies to build Saudi reactors and secure a long-term position in its nuclear infrastructure.

The main controversy is the possibility of a uranium enrichment facility in Saudi Arabia at a time when Washington seeks to roll back Iran’s nuclear capabilities. Yet that contradiction also points to the strategic rationale behind the agreement — the need to address Saudi concerns about the regional nuclear balance. The growth of Iranian power relative to its Arab neighbours has already encouraged the UAE to establish a civilian nuclear programme. A Saudi enrichment facility would be built by American companies and operate under US supervision. Such arrangements could reduce proliferation risks while giving Riyadh a measure of strategic parity with Tehran. Washington is also linking the nuclear deal to Saudi recognition of Israel. Riyadh has so far resisted joining the Abraham Accords. The nuclear agreement could therefore become part of a wider triangular negotiation among Washington, Riyadh and Tel Aviv over regional security, Palestinian statehood and the future of Arab-Israeli relations.

India is largely absent from the emerging nuclear industrial competition in the Middle East. This reflects decades of resistance in Delhi and Mumbai to reforming the atomic energy sector. The US-Saudi agreement should accelerate the implementation of the SHANTI Act and help prepare Indian industry to participate in the export of nuclear technologies across the Middle East. Politically, Delhi should support the US-Saudi agreement, underwritten by ironclad non-proliferation safeguards, and offer assistance to Riyadh’s civilian nuclear programme.

At a time when democracies across the world are becoming increasingly polarised, India faces a quieter but perhaps more profound crisis — the gradual death of dialogue

The Ideas Page

SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2026

I was asked to sing with an AI band. Here's why I said no



SONA MOHAPATRA

LAST EVENING, I found myself facing a decision I had not anticipated. I had been approached to sing an Odia bhajan — ‘Aahe Nila Shaila’ — for a band called Trilok. I have always believed that artistes who have acquired visibility, like me, should occasionally lend that visibility to younger musicians. An Odia bhajan, new talent, a cultural collaboration in the month of the Rath Yatra, it seemed like something I would naturally want to support.

Then I did a little research.

I discovered that Trilok was not a band in the sense in which most of us understand the word. Its members were virtual identities. It now has some men with painted faces to play live stages. The project had been developed as an AI-led “spiritual rock band” by a talent-management and media company, not by four musicians who had met, rehearsed, disagreed, failed and finally found a sound together.

I would have appreciated being told this at the very beginning. The fact that this was an AI-generated band with fictional identities was not a minor production detail. It was central to the nature of the invitation and materially changed my decision about whether I wished to associate my voice with it. I gave my answer the same night. It did not come easily, because I am not opposed to technology. In fact, I had to examine my own recent choices before arriving at it.

Every generation of musicians has feared some new machine. When synthesisers entered studios, many instrumentalists believed their livelihoods would disappear. The anxiety was understandable: Why hire an orchestra if a keyboard could imitate one? Why call a drummer when a machine could keep perfect time?

But the synthesiser did not bring music to an end. It became another instrument. Drum machines did not eliminate rhythm; they altered its vocabulary. Sampling, digital recording, Auto-Tune and home-produc-

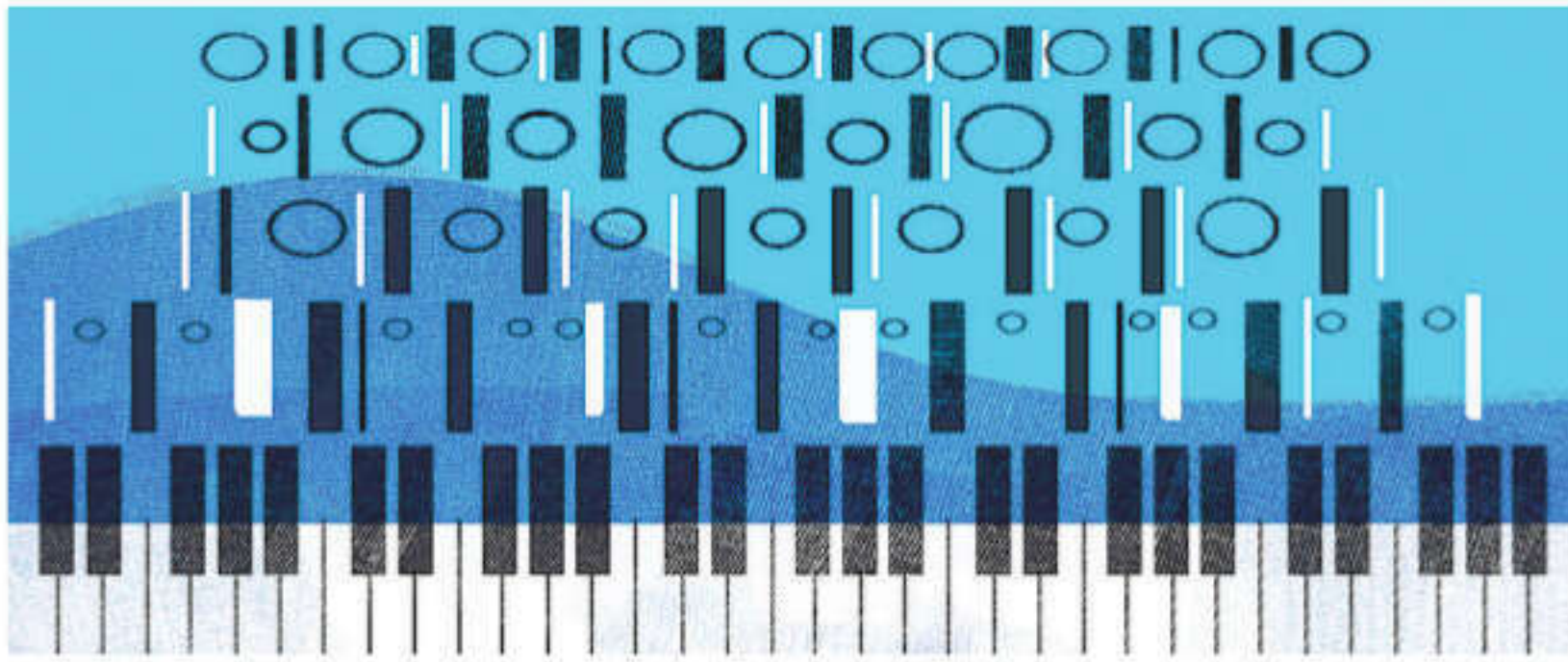


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

tion software all provoked similar alarm. Each was eventually absorbed into music. So it would be simplistic to declare that any use of AI is automatically an attack on art.

I recently released ‘Ghane Bhadra’, an original song whose video combines a live green-screen shoot of me performing with AI-assisted imagery. I am bodily present in the video. I sang the song. Human musicians played on it. AI helped us enlarge the visual canvas. It did not invent the artiste, replace the performance or conceal the people who made the music. That distinction matters to me.

Independent musicians in India work within an increasingly punishing economy. We write and produce original songs, pay for recordings, musicians, mixing, mastering, styling, shoots, editing, publicity and distribution without the machinery of a major film studio or record label. We then place that work on social-media platforms that depend on our content to hold audiences but do not pay most of us meaningfully for it. A new technology that allows us to tell a more ambitious visual story without waiting for a label's permission or budget can feel liberating.

This is why I had to ask myself an uncomfortable question: Was I being inconsistent? How could I use AI in my own video and then refuse to sing for an AI band?

The answer became clearer when I stopped treating all uses of AI as though they were the same.

There is a meaningful difference between an artiste using a ma-

chine and a corporation using one to manufacture the appearance of artistes. One begins with human authorship and uses technology to extend its reach. The other can create an entire synthetic identity around which a catalogue and business may be built. One helps a financially constrained artiste complete a labour of love. The other can produce material at a velocity no human musician can possibly match. One acknowledges the people at the centre. The other risks making them invisible.

When I examined the Trilok project, what troubled me was not simply that the members were digital avatars. It was the larger proposition. Devotional music is among the most enduring and commercially powerful musical traditions in India. The songs come with faith, familiarity and an audience already attached to them. A synthetic act built around beloved bhajans can rapidly create a catalogue without undergoing the slow, uncertain process through which musicians develop a voice.

Except for the guest collaborator, a known name used presumably to expand reach and gain credibility, all Trilok uploads just credit “Trilok” as the performer. That makes the question of authorship even more important. The point is not that no human work exists behind an AI output. Of course it does. But if human beings perform the labour while fictional identities receive the fame, where will value eventually accumulate?

And what happens when a rec-

ognised human singer is brought in?

My voice could give such a project something an avatar cannot manufacture: History, credibility, cultural location and emotional trust. My participation could tell listeners that this synthetic band had been accepted by a working artiste. Even unintentionally, I might help normalise a model that could ultimately reduce the space available to the world I come from. That was the ethical and moral line. Would I cross it?

There is another unresolved question. Generative music systems learn from large bodies of existing material. Around the world, creators are asking whether copyrighted work has been used for training with consent, transparency or compensation. The legal position is still contested. Technology has always learned from human knowledge. Artistes, too, learn from other artistes. But artistes do not ingest a million recordings at machine scale and then produce a competing catalogue within days. Scale changes the ethical character of the act.

I do not believe the answer is panic, prohibition or romantic speeches about returning to some pure pre-technological past. But artistes need to ask harder questions before lending their names and voices to synthetic acts. Who owns the resulting work? Who is credited? Was the training material licensed? Can a voice be cloned later? Is the human guest artiste helping build their own replacement? Is technology reducing the cost of expression or reducing the need to compensate creators? Is the audience being told clearly what it is hearing? And the final question: Where is the human being in this, and are we being invited to see them?

After thinking through, I knew I could not participate.

My use of AI in ‘Ghane Bhadra’ may still be questioned. That is fair. Artistes should not demand exemption from scrutiny simply because our intentions are good. I am also learning where my boundaries lie. But this experience clarified one of them. I will use technology to help human expressions travel further. I cannot knowingly lend my voice to make the human artiste disappear.

That is not fear of the future. It is a choice about the kind of future I am willing to help create.

The writer is a singer, producer and live performer

There is a meaningful difference between an artiste using a machine and a corporation using one to manufacture the appearance of artistes. One acknowledges the people at the centre. The other risks making them invisible

No victory, no deal, no exit for Trump in Iran



RAJAN KUMAR

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump is trapped in a strategic deadlock with Iran with no clear options. His strategy is unlikely to deliver a decisive military victory or a negotiated peace. And political and strategic constraints will not allow the US to withdraw either. Therefore, the US is likely to remain engaged in a prolonged low-intensity confrontation.

Negotiations remain the most viable option, but Trump's negotiating strategy suffers from inconsistency, inexperience and ineptitude. That bombing and negotiations can run in parallel is an inherently flawed and futile logic. In his negotiating team, there are three states and two individuals: Oman,

Qatar and Pakistan; and Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff. They were chosen for their loyalty to Trump rather than for real experience in strategic affairs.

A negotiation requires trust-building and neutrality. However, in the ongoing negotiations, negotiators are running with the hare and hunting with the hounds. Oman and Qatar are US allies, while Pakistan carries little political weight. They are not neutral, and their legitimacy is highly suspect. On the other side, Witkoff and Kushner are unable to restrain Trump from making provocative statements. Thus, the ongoing negotiations have achieved nothing substantial, besides an episodic ceasefire.

If Trump's negotiating strategies are flawed, his war strategy is no better. A victory requires full political and military commitment, entailing high economic cost. Trump

lacks the political or economic capital to risk a full escalation. His ratings are declining, his loyalists are jumping ship, and his party fears losses in the November midterm elections, in which 435 seats in the House of Representatives, 35 seats in the Senate, and 36 state governor seats are at stake. The Democrats have a modest edge in the election for the House of Representatives.

Further, the US's ability to project

Trump wanted regime change in Iran, but he cannot even keep the Strait of Hormuz open. He wanted a decimation of the Iranian military, but is incapable of protecting US allies

power beyond the region faces serious constraints. The cases of Afghanistan, Iraq and Syria clearly illustrate this limitation. But Trump seems to have little regard for strategic constraints.

Essentially, Trump has drawn the US again into a Middle Eastern quagmire. He began with the goal of regime change, but is unable to keep the Strait of Hormuz open. He desired a decimation of the Iranian military, but he is unable to protect the US's allies in the region. He sought to restore American hegemony in the region; instead, he has driven the Gulf states to deepen their ties with China.

At the global level, the Iran war has damaged the reputation of the US as a rational and capable superpower. Allies no longer view Washington as a reliable partner in winning a war, striking a deal or securing peace.

NATO refused to endorse Trump on Iran, the Gulf countries are cautious, and the Global South views the US as imperious, hegemonic and erratic. A Pew Research survey of 36 countries found that China is viewed more favourably than the US in 25 countries. The trend is likely to accelerate.

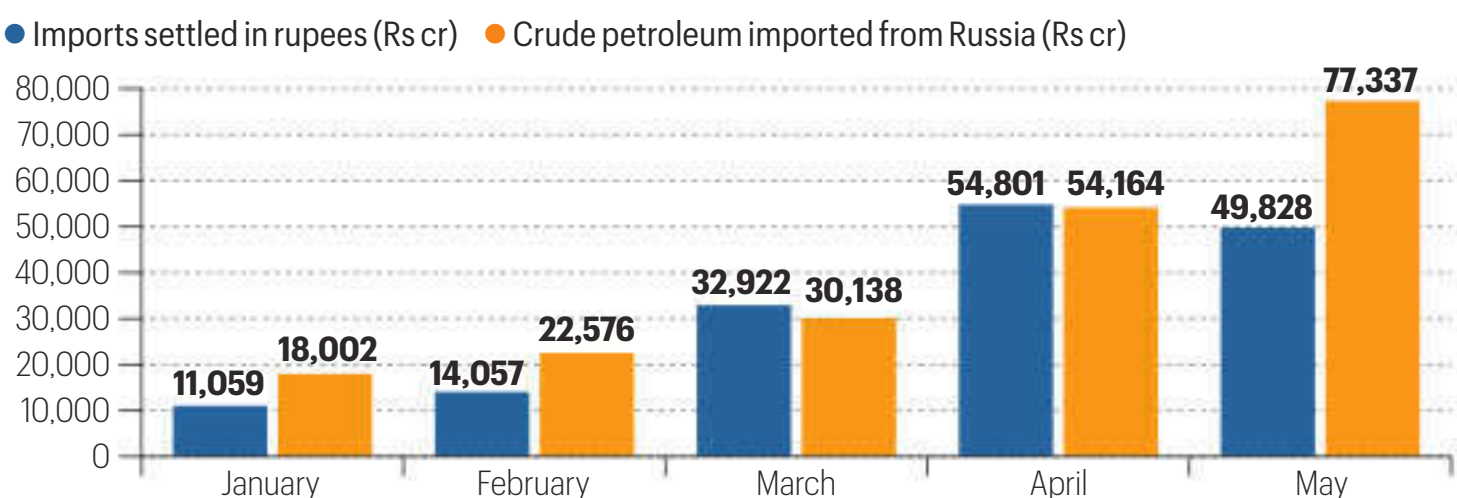
Trump's Iran strategy has reached a cul-de-sac where every option — war, withdrawal or deal — entails high strategic costs. In the short term, a further escalation involving other regional states is the most likely outcome. The leading countries of the Global South must step forward to broker a ceasefire and advance a de-escalation process. Strategic silence today may result in high strategic costs tomorrow.

The writer is professor, School of International Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, Delhi

AS RUSSIAN OIL PURCHASES SURGED

India paid \$15 bn of imports in rupees in March-May

• RUSSIAN OIL PURCHASES & PAYMENT FOR IMPORTS IN RUPEES



NOTE: DATA ON SETTLEMENT OF IMPORTS IN RUPEES IS FOR ALL MERCHANDISE GOODS. SOURCE: RBI, MINISTRY OF COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 24

EVEN AS the value of the rupee tumbled to multiple all-time lows following the onset of the war in West Asia, India used its domestic currency to pay for nearly \$15 billion worth of imports in March, April, and May.

The payment in rupees may have been for oil bought from Russia, whose share in India's oil imports surged after the US and Israel's attack on Iran in late February led to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

According to data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) this week, imports worth Rs 1.38 lakh crore were paid for in rupees during the three months in question, calculations by *The Indian Express* showed. This accounted for 7.1% of India's merchandise imports in the three months and is approximately equivalent to \$14.6 billion at the average exchange rate of 94-per-dollar that prevailed during March-May. In the previous three months — December 2025 to February 2026 — imports worth Rs 42,506 crore were settled in rupees, equal to 2.4% of total inbound shipments.

"The rupee's depreciation will only explain a small part of this increased rupee settlement of imports," said Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda, instead pointing to the sharp rise in India's purchases of Russian oil starting March.

The imports paid for in ru-

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Address genuine grievances of taxpayers fairly: FM to tax officers

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 24

Asking tax officers to "serve with humility", Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday said the honest taxpayers should be given the opportunity to correct bona fide errors, while "firm consequences" should be ensured for those who engage in deliberate tax evasion.

Speaking at the 167th Income Tax Day, Sitharaman in her message to the gathering of tax officials also said that the duration of processing timelines needs to be reduced

further along with focusing on shifting from "litigation management" to "litigation prevention" as a long-term objective.

Spelling out five Rs — recognise, respond, redress, reflect and reform — to the tax officers, Sitharaman said tax officials need to recognise every taxpayer's concern promptly, acknowledge that all grievances need timely attention; respond with clarity, courtesy, empathy ensuring taxpayers receive meaningful communication at each stage.

They should address genuine grievances fairly and within defined timelines, deliver timely and recent solutions; re-

flect on the root causes of grievances using complaints as an opportunity for institutional learning.

The FM also said that the officers should also reform the processes, systems and procedures continuously so that similar grievances become increasingly rare. "But sometimes we make the error of treating honest taxpayers with deliberate evaders and everybody goes home unhappy with this. We have to be intelligent. We have to be discreet...the authority conferred by tax law must always be exercised with humility," she said. **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

Renewed war erases Russian oil discounts

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 24

DISCOUNTS ON Russian oil for Indian refiners have vanished again amid the resurgence of conflict in West Asia and the sharp drop in energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz, a senior official with government-owned refiner Bharat Petroleum Corporation (BPCL) has said.

Amid all this, the demand for oil from other regions has shot up once again, leading to erosion of discounts on Russian oil — the mainstay of India's oil imports.

BPCL's Director (Finance) Vetsa Ramakrishna Gupta said that while Indian refiners are not receiving any discount offer for Russian crude in the prevailing market conditions, there is ample availability of Moscow's oil and crude from other sources in the market to keep India well-supplied.

Given the tightness in global energy supplies, Indian refiners are prioritising oil supply security over price considerations.

As for the US allowing its sanctions waiver on Russian oil purchases to lapse, Gupta said that the move has had no notable impact on buying behaviour as there are enough non-US-sanctioned suppliers of

Russian oil in the market.

The sanctions waiver, which was issued by the US to keep the global oil market well-supplied, lapsed on June 17, the same day on which the US-Iran MoU was inked.

"Russian oil was never sanctioned, only some vessels, service providers, and certain other entities were sanctioned (by the US). But if you are purchasing from other entities, you can very well continue to buy... We are buying completely from the non-sanctioned entities," Gupta told *The Indian Express* Thursday.

He added that the non-sanctioned sources of Russian oil supplies were more than adequate to meet India's demand and supplies till August-end were already tied up, with

"Volumes are available, only the price fluctuates. At times it (Russian oil) even commands a premium, instead of (the usual) discount, but enough volumes are available. In fact, because Russian refineries got impacted (due to Ukrainian attacks), surplus Russian oil volume was available for exports," he said.

Ever since the Russia-Ukraine war broke out in February 2022, Russian crude usually traded at a discount as numerous countries, predominantly in the West, shunned Moscow's oil.

• DIMINISHING GAINS

AFTER THE June 17 US-Iran MoU, energy flows through the strait started recovering, with hope in the market that supplies through the chokepoint would normalise steadily

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HOWEVER, THE recovery in energy flows from West Asia



lasted about three weeks, after which attacks on ships in the region resumed and tanker traffic crashed again

Highly import-dependent Indian refiners, however, were quick to step up their purchases of Russia's discounted barrels, catapulting Moscow to the position of New Delhi top source of crude within a few months. Before the Ukraine war, Russia was a peripheral oil supplier to India, with less than 2% share in India's oil import basket.

But amid the West Asia war, as vessel movements through the Strait of Hormuz — which usually accounted for a fifth go global oil flows — effectively came to a halt, refiners in India and even other parts of the world scrambled for oil from al-

ternative sources, leading to discount erosion and even premium on Russian oil.

After the June 17 US-Iran MoU, energy flows through the strait started recovering, with hope in the market that supplies through the chokepoint would normalise steadily.

The optimism led to a fall in oil prices; discounts on Russian oil at Indian ports had also widened to over \$10 per barrel to benchmark Brent crude in early July, as per industry estimates. However, the recovery in energy flows from West Asia lasted about three weeks, after which attacks on ships in the region re-

sumed and tanker traffic crashed again. Amid the West Asia crisis, as oil flows from the Gulf dried up, Russian crude became India's strongest energy security hedge.

As per Kpler data, India's Russian oil imports rose to around 2.6 million barrels per day (bpd) in June, accounting for over half of New Delhi's total crude imports. July arrivals are also tracking at healthy levels and could match or even exceed June's volumes, as per estimates. India depends on imports to meet over 88% of its crude oil needs, and over 40% of that was met by oil that came via the Strait of Hormuz.

In the months preceding the West Asia war, oil imports from Russia had reduced notably as the US imposed sanctions on Russian oil majors Rosneft and Lukoil, and amid trade pact negotiations with New Delhi and Washington.

The US made a meaningful reduction in Russian oil imports a prerequisite for scrapping its 25% additional penal tariff on India. But as supplies from West Asia dwindled due to the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz, Russian oil came to India's aid and volumes surged to historic highs.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

SEBI bars ex-Axis MF chief dealer from market for 7 yrs, 20 others too face ban

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, July 24

THE SECURITIES and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has barred former Axis Mutual Fund chief dealer Viresh Joshi from accessing the securities market for seven years, saying that he orchestrated a front-running scheme using confidential information about the fund house's impending trades.

The regulator also barred 20 others from the market for 3-7

years in its final order in the front running case.

SEBI also slapped Rs 3 crore penalty on Joshi and a total of Rs 7.4 crore from 21 persons involved in the case. Front-running in a mutual fund is an illegal trading practice in which an insider — such as a fund manager, dealer or broker — uses material non-public information about a large pending trade on behalf of the mutual fund or a client to execute personal trades ahead of that order,

intending to profit from the price movement that occurs when the fund's trade is executed. During the investigation after the fraud was detected in 2022, it was found that Joshi shared non-public information about impending orders of a big client to an external co-conspirator, Priyesh Kurani. Priyesh on the instructions of Viresh would place orders in certain conduit/mule accounts of 15 others, the SEBI orders said. **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

• SEBI HAS PROPOSED ALLOWING PORTFOLIO MANAGERS TO INVEST IN OVERSEAS LISTED EQUITY & DEBT SECURITIES, SECURITIES THAT ARE YET TO BE LISTED AND A LIMITED EXPOSURE TO UNLISTED DEBT INSTRUMENTS

PMS overhaul: What SEBI has proposed and what it means for investors

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 24

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has proposed a sweeping review of the SEBI (Portfolio Managers) Regulations, 2020, seeking to modernise the framework governing portfolio management services (PMS).

The SEBI consultation paper, released on July 23, comes against the backdrop of rapid expansion in the PMS industry and changing investor preferences. According to SEBI, assets managed by portfolio managers have more than doubled over the past six years, prompting the need for a fresh regulatory framework. For investors and market participants, the PMS reforms, including mutual fund only category and permission to invest in

overseas securities and to-be-listed securities, signal SEBI's broader approach of adapting regulations to the growing complexity of India's capital markets while ensuring that investor interests remain at the centre of the regulatory framework.

What is PMS?

Portfolio management service (PMS) is registered under the SEBI (Portfolio Managers) Regulations, 2020. It is a professional investment service where a qualified fund manager takes charge of the equity, debt and other securities portfolio of a customer — who is a high net-worth investor.

Only corporate entities, companies, or LLPs with SEBI registration can legally offer these services in India. SEBI mandates that no PMS provider

can accept less than Rs 50 lakh per client. The assets under management (AUM) of the PMS industry reached Rs 42.61 lakh crore as on May 2026 from Rs 18.07 lakh crore as on April 2019.

The total number of clients as of May 2026 stood at 2.19 lakh from 1.5 lakh in April 2019. The total number of portfolio managers has also increased from 226 in the year 2020, when PM Regulations were revamped, to 515 as on May 31, 2026, an increase of more than two times from 2020.

Wider investment universe

One of the biggest changes proposed is the expansion of investment avenues available to portfolio managers. Currently, PMS providers face restrictions on investing in certain asset classes that are accessible to



Assets managed by portfolio managers have more than doubled over the past six years. REUTERS

other regulated investment vehicles. SEBI has proposed allowing portfolio managers to invest in overseas listed equity and debt securities, securities that are yet to be listed and a limited exposure to unlisted debt instruments. The move is intended to align PMS

regulations more closely with those governing mutual funds and alternative investment funds (AIFs). The regulator has also proposed to expand the permissible investment universe to permit investments in "to be listed" securities. This would enable

investors to gain exposure to broader market opportunities. Further, SEBI's consultation paper has proposed that a portfolio manager offering discretionary portfolio management services (DPMS) may be permitted to invest up to 10% of its client's AUM in investment grade unlisted debt securities. The regulator believes that broader investment flexibility would enable portfolio managers to design more diversified and customised portfolios for high-net-worth clients. The proposals also acknowledge growing investor demand for global diversification and access to a wider range of investment opportunities.

Currently, PMS portfolio managers are not permitted to invest client funds in foreign securities. However, resident Indians are allowed to invest in

foreign securities under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS), subject to an overall limit of USD \$250,000 per financial year.

New MF-only category of portfolio managers

SEBI has proposed a simplified "Mutual Fund-only" PMS framework with lowered entry barriers. This proposed framework aims to effectively serve mass-affluent investors who seek professional portfolio management services for their mutual fund investments.

This framework is introduced to enable portfolio managers intending to exclusively manage client investments only in direct plans of mutual funds schemes including Exchange Traded Funds (ETFs) and Specialized Investment Funds (SIFs). PMS managers

will have to obtain a separate registration as a MF-PMS. It has proposed that the minimum client investment requirement should be reduced from Rs 50 lakh to Rs 25 lakh. It has also proposed that the minimum net worth required for applicants may be reduced from Rs 5 crore to Rs 2 crore. A mutual fund distributor (MFD) registered under the MF-PMS framework will be required to maintain arm's length relationship between its activities as an MFD and MF-PMS through a separately identifiable department or division. The MF-PMS will be required to have client level segregation for its services as an MFD and MF-PMS. The same client will not be offered both services by the same entity under MFD and MF-PMS, Sebi says.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• GLOBAL

New US tariffs leave India better off than competitors



RAVI DUTTA MISHRA

THE Donald Trump administration has begun its efforts to reconstruct its International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs that were declared illegal by the US Supreme Court in February.

Starting Friday, the administration began imposing new tariffs under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974 on the grounds that the 60 countries it targets — all major exporters to the US — have failed to take measures to stop imports of goods manufactured through forced labour.

According to the US Trade Representative (USTR), countries that import goods made by forced labour get an artificial cost advantage while exporting goods, forcing American workers to compete on an uneven field. The main target, however, is clear: China. These tariffs are largely meant to force countries to cut their dependence on China, which the US is in a trade war with. The US State department says the country uses forced prison labour to make goods and injects these into international supply chains.

The new US architecture is yet to fully take shape. Only the first set of tariffs has been imposed, and multiple other Section 301 tariff investigations are still ongoing.

India, as of now, faces 10% tariffs, down from the 12.5% when the USTR first proposed the tariffs in March. The Trump administration is expected to announce the results of another Section 301 investigation, this one focusing on excess manufacturing capacity. The lower rates for Indian goods come with New Delhi engaging in negotiations with the US for over a year, stepping up energy imports from Washington and lowering duty for some US goods.

On June 14, India also amended its foreign trade policy to explicitly ban the import of goods produced using forced labour. The USTR considered this an improvement, placing India in the lower-tariff category alongside 16 other economies.

India's grouping

The USTR's stated reason for imposing the new Section 301 tariffs is the import of Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vn2VRb6RGjOKH6oBd0F>

• The four-tier US tariff structure

Brackets countries based on measures they have taken to prevent imports of products made through forced labour

	Section 301 tariffs	Number of countries
Most favourable group	10% net of MFN tariff rate	EU, Taiwan
Second-most favourable group	Flat 10% (on top of MFN tariff rate)	17 (including India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Canada, Mexico)
Third-most favourable group	12.5% net of MFN tariff rate	3 (Japan, South Korea, Switzerland)
Least favourable	Flat 12.5% (on top of MFN tariff rate)	38 (including China, Vietnam, Russia, Brazil)

SOURCE: GLOBAL TRADE ALERT, USTR; NOTE: MFN REFERS TO MOST-FAVOURABLE NATION



goods made by forced labour.

But the four-tier tariff structure — ostensibly bracketing countries based on their measures to curb imports of forced labour goods — suggests that they were imposed along geopolitical lines. All 60 countries under investigation were found guilty — the most favoured countries or groupings remain the European Union (EU) and Taiwan, and the most unfavourable Vietnam and China.

The USTR explained that for a product of the EU or Taiwan, where the product's most-favoured nation (MFN) tariff is less than 10%, the US shall impose a Section 301 tariff in a way that the sum of the MFN tariff and the Section 301 tariff shall be 10%. In cases where a product's MFN tariff is greater than or equal to 10%, the section 301 tariff would not be imposed.

In trade parlance, MFN rates are duties that countries use across the board for all countries. As per World Trade Organisation (WTO) norms, MFN rates are the standard, non-discriminatory tariff or tax levels that a WTO member country promises to apply to imports from other WTO members.

The second-most favourable rate has been offered to India and 16 other countries, where a flat addition of 10% has been imposed. This would mean that the Section 301 rate of 10% would be added to the current MFN rate. Countries in this bracket in-

Rebuilding the tariff regime

The new US tariff architecture — meant to reconstruct the IEEPA tariffs struck down by the Supreme Court — is yet to fully take shape.

Only the first set of tariffs has been imposed, and multiple Section 301 investigations are still ongoing.



US President Donald Trump at the White House on Thursday. AP

clude Argentina, Bangladesh, Cambodia, Canada, Ecuador, El Salvador, Guatemala, Honduras, India, Indonesia, Jordan, Malaysia, Mexico, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, the UK, and Trinidad and Tobago. Notably, when the investigation began in March, Pakistan had lower tariffs than India.

Higher rates on competitors

The third-most favourable grouping includes Japan, Korea and Switzerland. These countries had, in earlier tariff structures, received better rates than India. The USTR said these three countries will now face a 12.5% rate. However, just like countries in the first category, the overall tariffs will be capped at 12.5% itself if the MFN tariff is less than that level.

“...where such product's MFN tariff is greater than or equal to 12.5%, the Trade Representative shall impose a Section 301 tariff of zero,” the USTR said in its finding.

The least favourable group had 38 countries, including top Indian competitors such as Vietnam and China. The USTR said these countries, like the second category, face a flat 12.5% rate, which means 12.5% over and above the MFN rates. These two countries have not only been hit with higher tariffs under the “forced labour” category but are also facing more Section 301 tariffs than India. Exporters said that with Vietnam and China facing steeper rates than India, source-

ing requirements could shift to India.

'No credible alternative'

In the wake of the tariff measures imposed by the US since early 2025, a significant decline in India's merchandise exports was widely anticipated. But trade data from the Ministry of Commerce reveals that India's exports to the US actually grew 0.9% (or \$801.7 million) from \$86.5 billion to \$87.3 billion, an Indian Council for Research on International Economic Research (ICRIER) report released in July said.

This, however, was driven by exports of products in the exclusion list, which primarily included pharmaceutical and electronic goods. “In 2025-26, exports of products covered under the exclusion list rose sharply by 24.5%, climbing from \$29.4 billion to \$36.6 billion. Exports of non-excluded products, by contrast, fell by 11.2% over the same period, declining from US\$ 57.1 billion to US\$ 50.7 billion - a contraction that reflects the true effect of the tariff measures imposed by the United States,” the ICRIER report said.

Even as India aggressively scouts for newer markets through free trade agreements, the report pointed out that the capacity of alternative markets to absorb India's US export losses is “highly uneven... for some product categories, partial for others, and altogether absent for several”.

SACRED NAMES

● ‘Jagannath Dham’ and ‘Shree Kshetra’ are sacred words associated with Puri, ‘Mahaprasad’ refers to the food offered to the deities and ‘Nilchakra’ is the eight-spoked metal wheel atop the temple.

● ‘Koili Vaikuntha’ refers to the sacred garden inside the shrine where the deities are made from the sacred wooden logs and old deities are buried after consecration of new idols.

using the word “dham” for the Digha shrine amounted to violation of the “scriptural injunctions and long-established tradition” of Lord Jagannath. The controversy ended last month after Suwendu Adhikari, the new Chief Minister of Bengal's BJP-led government, said that using “dham” for the Digha temple was not in accordance with “Sanatan culture” and removed it from the name.

Trademark registration

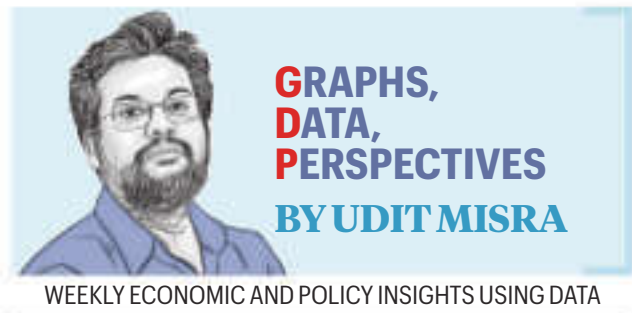
Trademark registration is the legal process of protecting a unique brand — like a name, logo, symbol or slogan — associated with any organisation. Established in 1940, India's Trade Marks Registry administers the provisions of the Trade Marks Act, 1999, and the Trade Marks Rules, 2017. The Registry is a resource and information centre and facilitates matters relating to trademarks in India.

The Act aims to provide for the registration of trademarks relating to goods and services, ensure better protection and prevent their fraudulent use.

Publication of these words in trademarks journals amounts to preliminary approval, as final certificates are issued if no objections are received within three months.

• ECONOMY

Alongside Centre, states' education expenditure too declined over past 12 years



THE ONGOING youth protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi and in several other cities, demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and seeking education reforms, have brought attention to the state of education in India.

The Indian Express had recently explained how the Education Ministry's share of the Union Budget had sharply declined over the past 12 years — from 4.6% in 2013-14 (the last year that the Congress-led UPA government was in power) to 2.5% in 2025-26. The fall suggests that the BJP-led NDA government reduced emphasis on education.

As a subject of policymaking, however,

education is not the sole preserve of the Union government.

Common subject

Education falls under the Concurrent list in the Seventh Schedule of the Indian Constitution.

The schedule essentially divides powers and responsibilities between the Union and state governments through three lists — Union, State and Concurrent. Both the Centre and state governments can legislate on subjects under the Concurrent list.

So, how do states act on the subject of education and what policy significance do they attach to it? A broad marker of priority is to examine the share of a state's total expenditure on education. The table and chart alongside provide a glimpse of where things stand.

Apart from providing an average for all states and Union Territories, the table also looks at a selection of states to provide a geographically and politically diverse sample for the country.

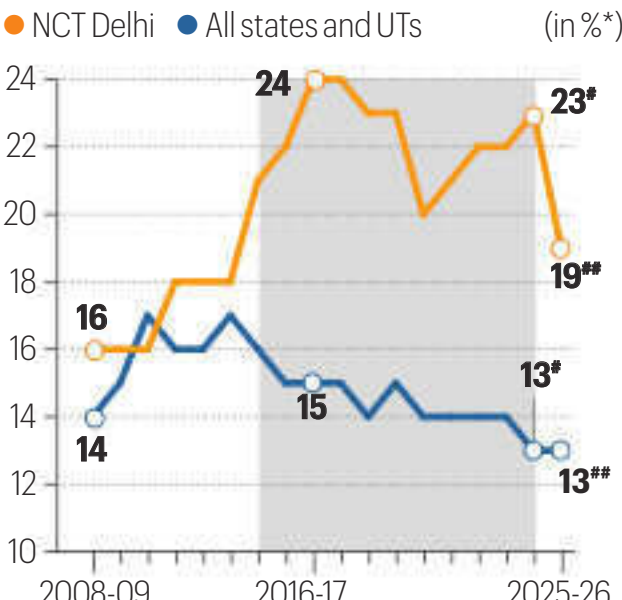
• State of education expenditure

State/Union Territory	Expenditure on education (2025-26)*	State-wise gross enrolment ratio (2024-25)**
Bihar	20	45
Gujarat	13	61
Kerala	12	94
Tamil Nadu	12	89
West Bengal	14	75
NCT Delhi	19	92
All states and UTs	13	69

*AS PERCENTAGE OF AGGREGATE EXPENDITURE **FOR SECONDARY EDUCATION *2024-25 (RE) **2025-26 (BE) SOURCE: RBI NOTE: INCLUDES EXPENDITURE ON SPORTS, ART AND CULTURE UNDER REVENUE EXPENDITURE AND CAPITAL OUTLAY

For some context about the status of education, while many variables could be

• AAP effect on education spend



chosen, the table shows data on gross enrolment ratio (GER) at the secondary edu-

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+2RvD-RGf9mljMzg1> below the national average. Longer-term data — going back to 2008-09 — shows that Tamil Nadu has largely tracked and then fallen just behind the national level. Kerala used to allocate a higher share than the national average until the Covid-19 year of 2020, and has lagged since then. Gujarat, too, has lagged behind the national average more often than not.

What is concerning is that the national average of all states and UTs itself has been trending down, as the chart alongside shows. After staying at around 17% in 2013-14, the average share of expenditure on education has gradually fallen. This fall is crucial, since it mirrors the fall in the share of money spent by the Union government as well.

There are exceptions to this trend, though. Take the Union Territory of Delhi under the Aam Aadmi Party government, which initially made health and education the key pillars of its pitch to voters. Between 2014-15 and 2024-25, education's share went up sharply, in contrast to the falling trend of the national average.